

In Colombia's Roadless Jungles, Traditional Midwives Are a Lifeline--But They Want Respect

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Nohemí Manco was 14 when her sister went into labor in their remote home in Unguía, Colombia, a place of dense jungle, waterfalls, and zero hospitals. With no doctor or ambulance, Manco relied on what she'd absorbed from watching her mother: where to cut the **umbilical cord**, which eases pain, how to care for a newborn. "I loved it. I wasn't even scared," she recalls. Four decades later, Manco, now 53, estimates she has delivered about 1,200 babies. She's part of a vast network of "**parteras tradicionales**" traditional midwives who serve as the primary healthcare providers for pregnant women in Colombia's isolated Pacific region. In these areas, a hospital can be hours or even days away, making midwives crucial to reducing **maternal** and infant deaths. "Midwives are the main and most constant resource for rural communities," says Liany Katherine Ariza Ruiz, a public health researcher at Pontificia Universidad Javeriana. Yet despite their vital role, many midwives say they face **discrimination** from Colombia's formal healthcare system. They report being mocked, dismissed, and sometimes barred from hospitals when accompanying patients. "For a while, we felt the tradition was being lost because there was so much **discrimination**," says Yuvianis Florez, a 36-year-old midwife. A 2026 survey identified at least 1,742 traditional midwives active in the region; 11% of them men, but the population is aging rapidly. Nearly half are over 60, and 40% are **illiterate**. Florez and Manco don't reject modern medicine; they want collaboration. "We want to work together to ensure the safety of rural women," Florez explains. Manco believes midwives can also be advocates for education and **reproductive health**. As younger generations show less interest, the fight isn't just for respect; it's for survival of a centuries-old tradition that continues to save lives where roads and clinics don't reach.

Word Treasure

parteras tradicionales -- Spanish term for traditional midwives who deliver babies without formal medical training.

umbilical cord -- The tube that connects a baby to its mother before birth, carrying food and oxygen.

maternal -- Relating to mothers, especially during pregnancy and childbirth.

discrimination -- Unfair treatment of a person or group based on prejudice.

illiterate -- Unable to read or write.

reproductive health -- A person's well-being in matters related to having children and sexual health.

Background you need

Unguía is a municipality in the Chocó department of Colombia, a region covered by dense rainforest and lacking roads, making travel to cities extremely difficult.

Traditional midwifery has been practiced for centuries in many parts of the world, especially where formal healthcare is inaccessible; in Colombia, these midwives are called parteras.

The Pontificia Universidad Javeriana (a leading Colombian university founded in 1623) conducts public health research in these remote areas.

Globally, maternal mortality rates are higher in rural regions without skilled birth attendants, which is why the United Nations targets reducing these deaths.

Discrimination against traditional birth attendants is not unique to Colombia; similar tensions between formal health systems and indigenous healers exist in other countries.

Break it down

LEAD: Nohemí Manco's first experience delivering a baby at 14 in a remote jungle.

+ detail: She wasn't scared, learned from her mother.

KEY ROLE: Traditional midwives are the primary health providers in isolated Pacific Colombia.

+ WHY: Hospitals are hours or even days away.

+ QUOTE: Researcher Ariza Ruiz calls them the 'main and most constant resource.'

DISCRIMINATION: Midwives report mockery and being barred from hospitals.

+ IMPACT: Tradition felt at risk of being lost (Florez quote).

+ SURVEY DATA: 1,742 active, 11% men, many over 60, 40% illiterate.

SEEKING COLLABORATION: Midwives want to work with modern medicine, not reject it.

+ ADDITIONAL ROLE: Manco believes they can advocate for education and reproductive health.

OPEN QUESTION: Can the tradition survive if younger generations lose interest?

Why it matters

This story highlights the challenges of providing healthcare in remote areas and the importance of bridging traditional and modern medicine--a debate that affects rural communities worldwide.

Test what you remember

1. Approximately how many babies does Nohemí Manco estimate she has delivered?

- ☐ (A) 500
- ☐ (B) 800
- ☐ (C) 1,200
- ☐ (D) 1,500

2. What percentage of traditional midwives in the 2026 survey were men?

- ☐ (A) 5%
- ☐ (B) 11%
- ☐ (C) 20%
- ☐ (D) 30%

3. What challenge do midwives face from Colombia's formal healthcare system?

- ☐ (A) Lack of supplies
- ☐ (B) Discrimination and mockery
- ☐ (C) Low pay
- ☐ (D) Overwork

4. Why are midwives crucial in Colombia's Pacific region?

- ☐ (A) They are cheaper than doctors
- ☐ (B) Hospitals are hours or days away
- ☐ (C) The government banned hospitals
- ☐ (D) They have better equipment

5. What does midwife Yuvianis Florez say midwives want?

- ☐ (A) To replace modern medicine
- ☐ (B) Collaboration with the formal healthcare system
- ☐ (C) More hospitals in rural areas
- ☐ (D) Recognition from the government only

6. What concern is raised about the future of traditional midwifery in the article?

- ☐ (A) Too many young people are interested
- ☐ (B) The population is aging and younger generations show less interest
- ☐ (C) They are being overrun by male midwives
- ☐ (D) Hospitals are closing down

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Lifesaving community care:** Traditional midwives are essential: they deliver thousands of babies in places with no doctors, drastically lowering the risk of mothers and infants dying alone. Their work is a testament to community resilience and the power of inherited knowledge.
- 2. Harmful discrimination:** Despite their vital role, midwives face mockery and exclusion from hospitals. This disrespect not only hurts their dignity but can also endanger patients if midwives are denied backup support, showing a failure of the formal system to acknowledge local realities.
- 3. A fading tradition:** With nearly half of the midwives over 60 and high illiteracy rates, the practice is at risk. Without young recruits and formal recognition, centuries of knowledge could disappear, leaving a healthcare vacuum in the jungle.
- 4. Path to integration:** If collaboration were achieved--combining midwives' community trust with medical training--it could become a model for other remote regions. Integrating midwives into official health strategies could improve maternal health while preserving cultural heritage.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):